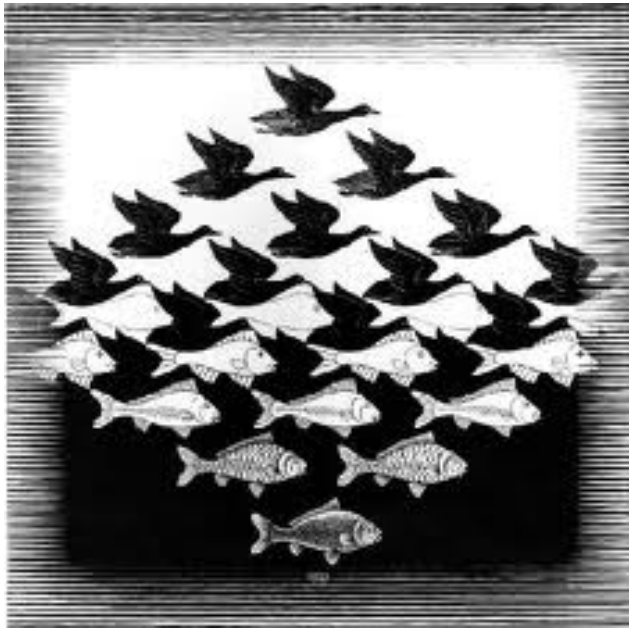
If You Don't Understand Habits, How Can You Hope To Change Them? Challenges And Opportunities To Encourage Sustainable Living

Bas Verplanken
University of Bath, U.K.



Climate Change

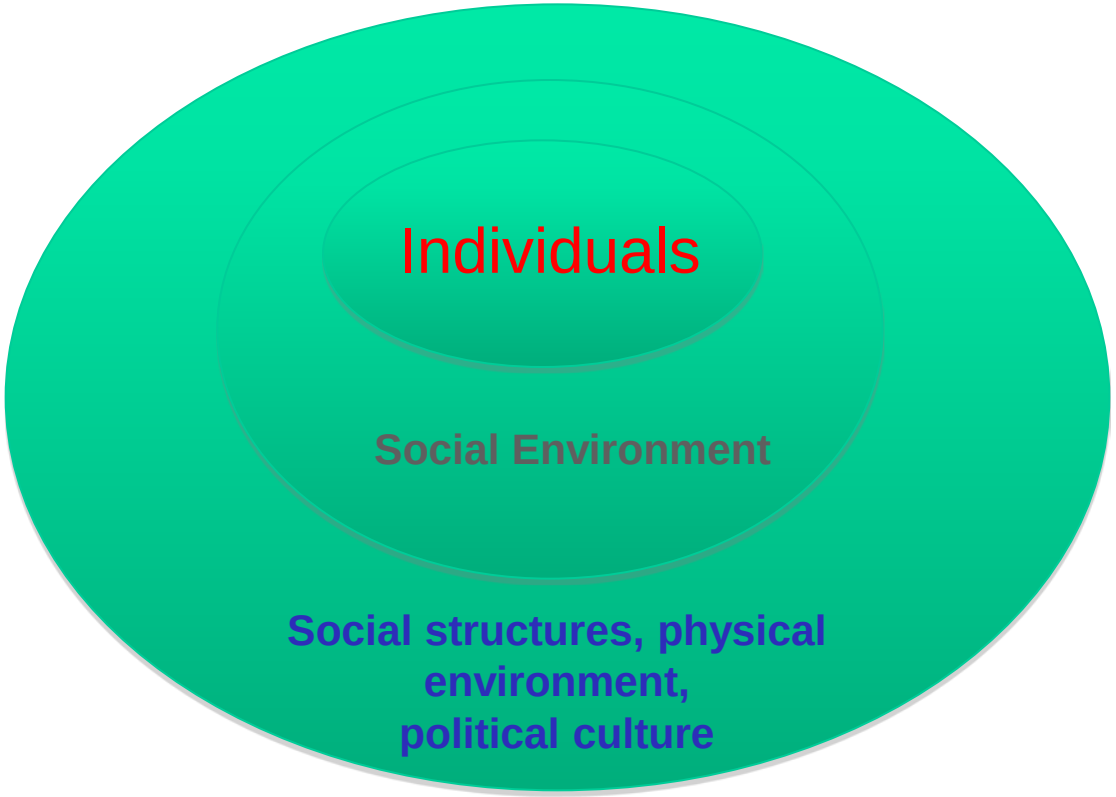


The Key Problem

<< Whilst I do acknowledge that the issue of climate change is probably the most important problem humanity has faced, I surprise myself in my own ability to ignore this. >>

(Anonymous participant, June 2012)

Environmental Behaviour



Environmental Behaviour



Environmental Behaviour



When was the last time you did something for the first time?

<< Most of the time, what we do is what we do most of the time >>

(Townsend & Bever, 2001)



<<… between a third and a half of all behaviors listed were classified as habits, given that they were performed just about every day and usually in the same location >>

(Wood, Quinn, & Kashy, 2002)

Habit

1. Things we do regularly.
2. A practice or custom.
3. A dominant disposition.
4. Addiction.
5. Bad behaviour.

Three Pillars of Habit



Repetition

Repetition

- Frequency of past behaviour: ”the psychologists’ definition of habit”

Repetition

- Frequency of past behaviour: ”the psychologists’ definition of habit”
- Cumulative impact of repetition

Repetition

- Frequency of past behaviour: ”the psychologists’ definition of habit”
- Cumulative impact of repetition
- Problem 1: How frequent is ”habitual”

Repetition

- Frequency of past behaviour: ”the psychologists’ definition of habit”
- Cumulative impact of repetition
- Problem 1: How frequent is ”habitual”
- Problem 2: Frequent behaviour is not necessarily habitual

Repetition

- Frequency of past behaviour: ”the psychologists’ definition of habit”
- Cumulative impact of repetition
- Problem 1: How frequent is ”habitual”
- Problem 2: Frequent behaviour is not necessarily habitual
- *A history of repetition is a necessary, but not a sufficient condition for a habit*

Three Pillars of Habit



Repetition

Automaticity

Automaticity

- The ”fluency” of habitual behaviour

”The Four Horsemen of Automaticity”

(Bargh 1994)



- Minimal awareness
- Lack of conscious intent
- Difficulty of control
- Mental efficiency

Three Pillars of Habit



Repetition

Automaticity

Context-Cued



Habits are Context-Cued

- Habits are triggered by cues in stable contexts

Time
Location
Specific situations or objects
Specific people
Mood
Physiological states
Social and cultural practices
Other habits

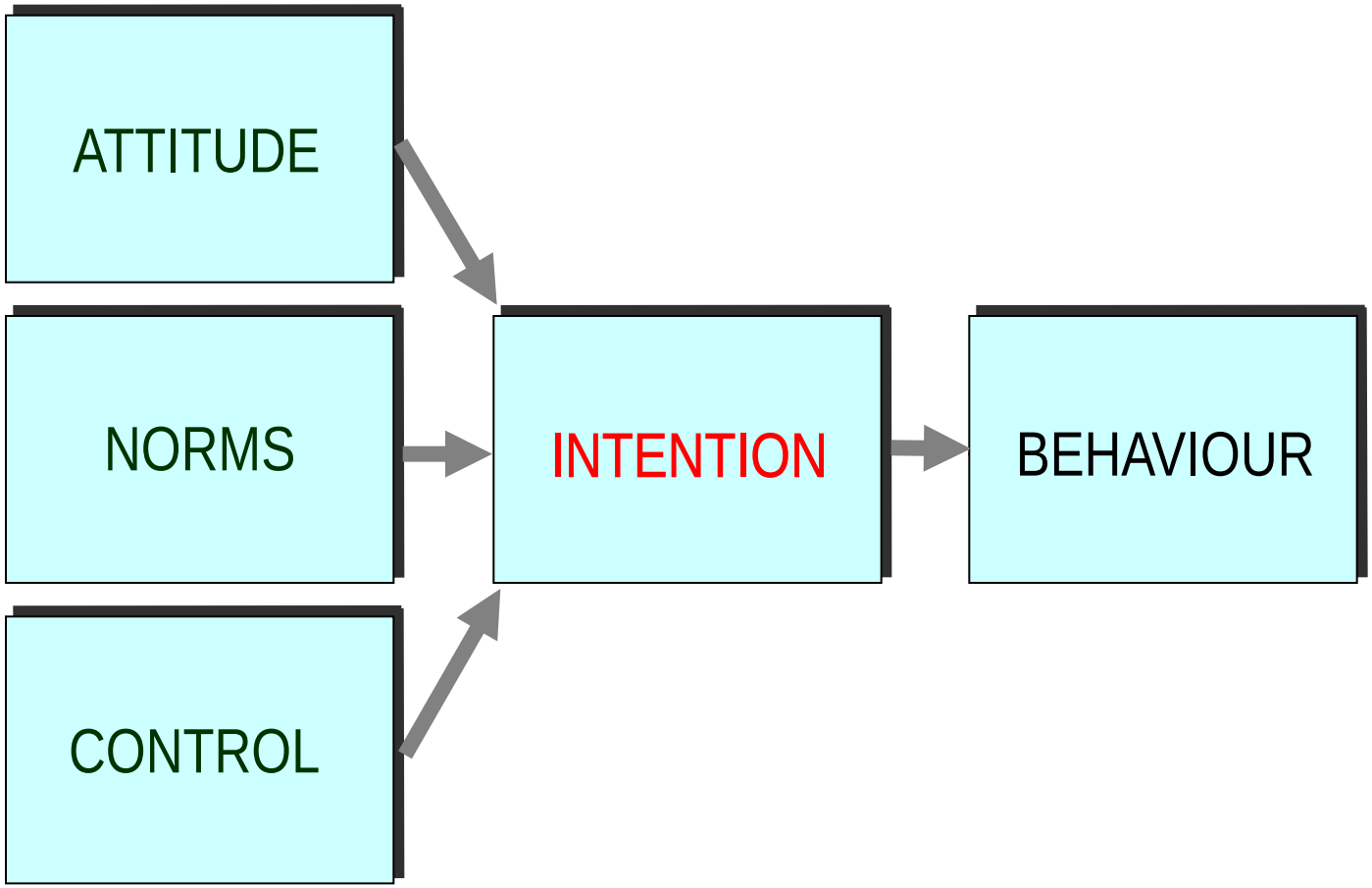
Habits are Context-Cued

- Habits are triggered by cues in stable contexts
- Control of behaviour is delegated from 'willpower' (i.e., intention, motivation) to the behavioural environment (i.e., cues)

Habits are Context-Cued

- Habits are triggered by cues in stable contexts
- Control of behaviour is delegated from 'willpower' (i.e., intention, motivation) to the behavioural environment (i.e., cues)
- Not in line with models of behaviour in social, health, consumer, and environmental psychology

Theory of Planned Behaviour



Self-Report Habit Index

Behaviour 'X' is something…

… I do frequently.

… I do automatically.

… I do without thinking.

… that would require effort not to do.

… I do without having to consciously remember.

… that makes me feel weird if I do not do it.

… that belongs to my daily routine.

… I start doing before I realize I'm doing it.

… I would find hard not to do.

… I have no need to think about doing.

… that's typically "me."

… I have been doing for a long time.

Verplanken & Orbell (2003), *Journal of Applied Social Psychology*

Self-Report Habit Index

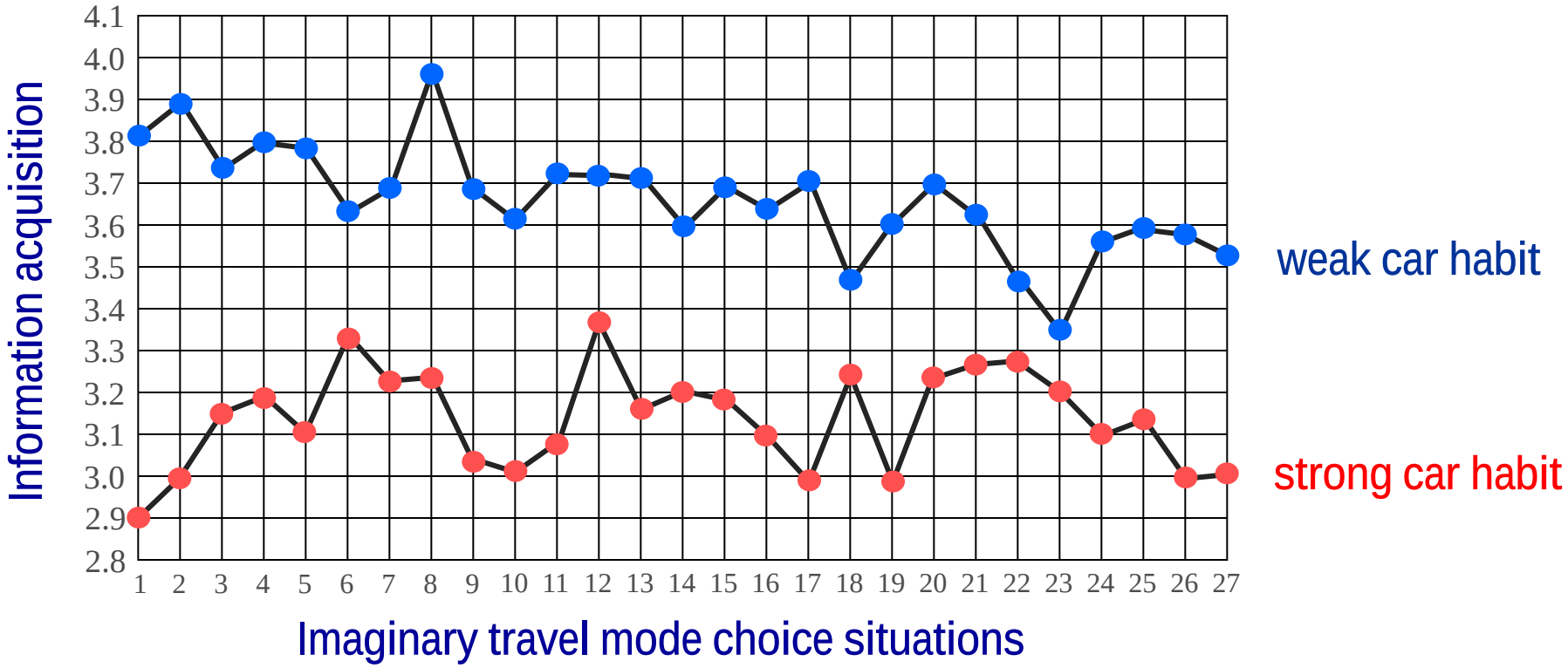
- Facets:
  - Experience of repetition
  - Minimal awareness
  - Lack of conscious intent
  - Difficulty to control
  - Efficiency
  - Identity

Verplanken & Orbell (2003), *Journal of Applied Social Psychology*

Consequences of Habituation

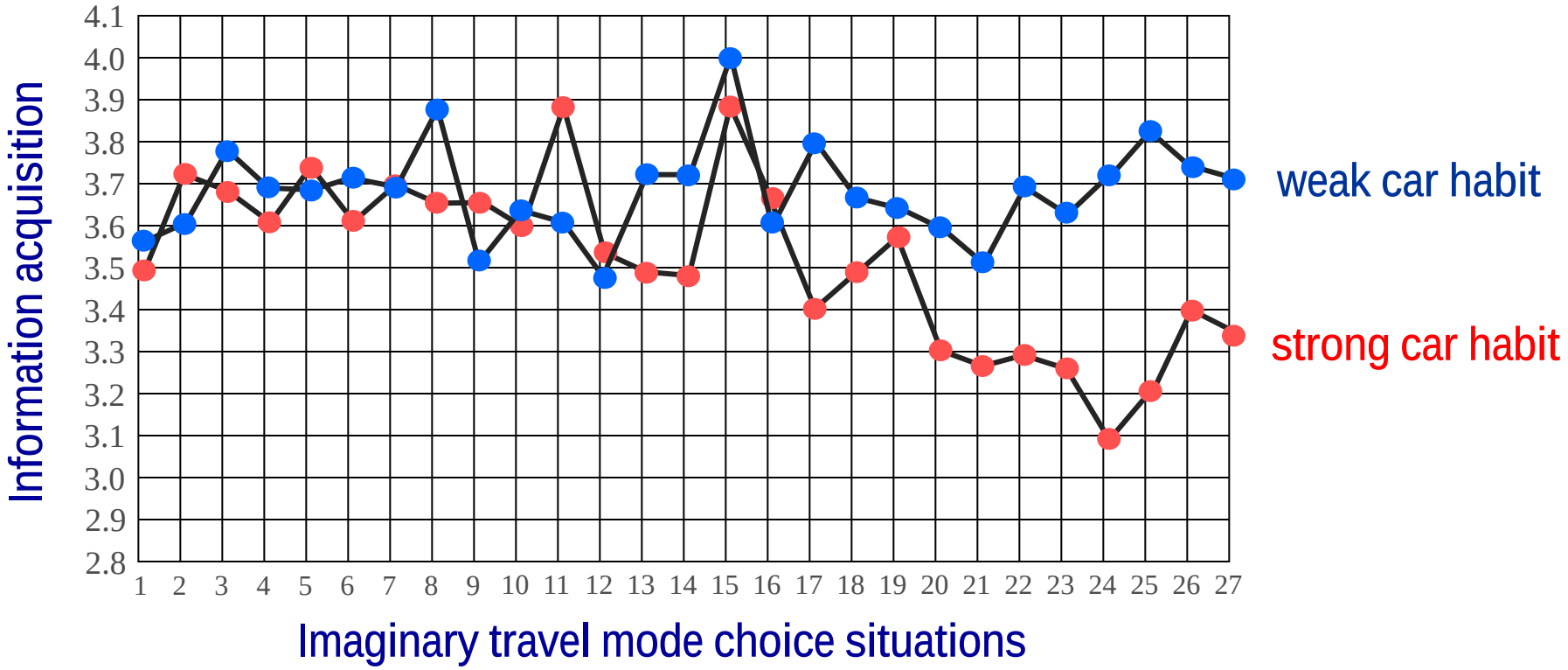
- Tunnel vision: lack of attention to information

Attention to New Information



Verplanken, Aarts, van Knippenberg (1997), *European Journal of Social Psychology*

Attention to New Information



Verplanken, Aarts, van Knippenberg (1997), *European Journal of Social Psychology*

Consequences of Habituation

- Tunnel vision: lack of attention to information
- Disjunction between attitudes/intentions and behaviour

Intention-Behaviour Relation

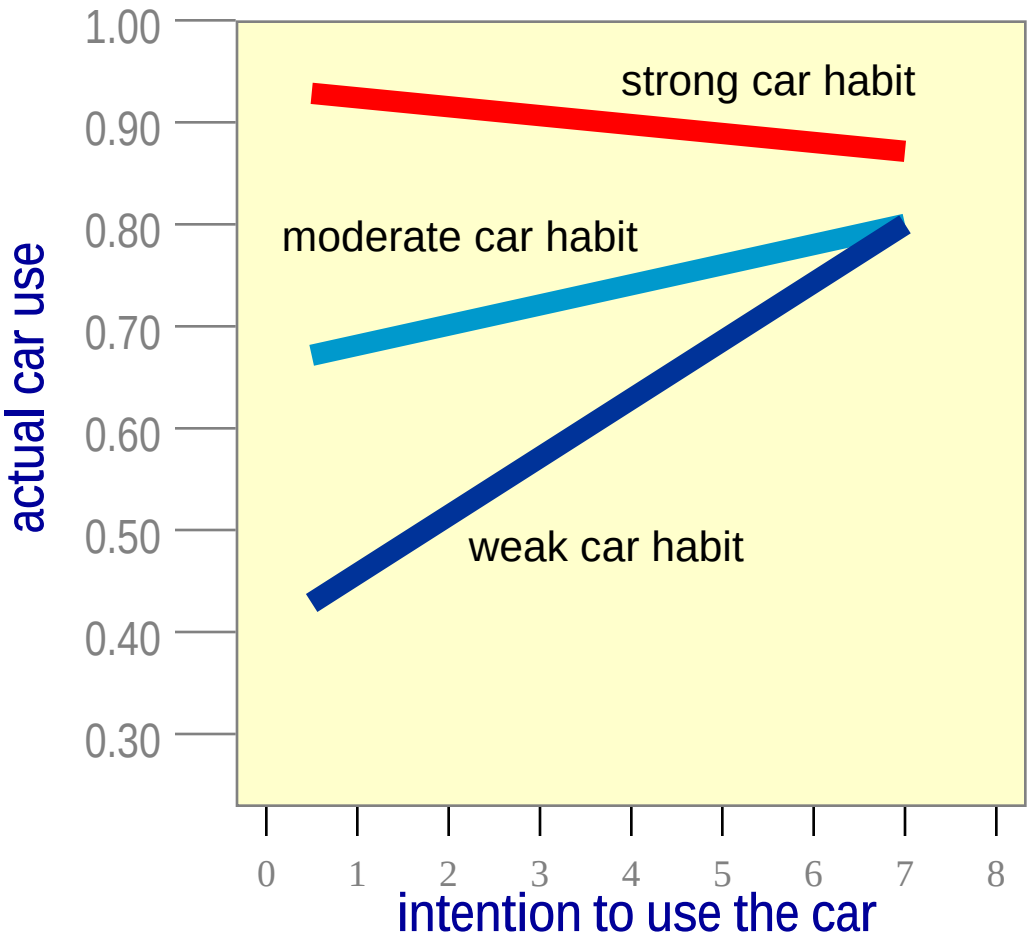


INTENTION → BEHAVIOUR

survey → travel diary

Verplanken, Aarts, van Knippenberg, & Moonen (1998), *British Journal of Social Psychology*

Intention-Behaviour Relation



Verplanken, Aarts, van Knippenberg, & Moonen (1998), *British Journal of Social Psychology*

The Habitual Consumer

acts repetitively
on the automatic pilot
under the same circumstances
is not interested in your information
is not 'driven' or motivated

BUT

is happy with his/her habit

Promoting Sustainable Behaviours

Using public transport . Installing insulation . Recycling . Buying local . Taking the train to domestic destinations . Reading energy labels . Switching off appliances at night . Cycling to work . Installing a smart energy meter . Waste less food . Ethical spending . Protesting against nuclear power . Buying organic food . Using a shopping bag . Eco-driving . Avoiding overseas flights . Washing at 30 degrees Celcius . Switching off lights . Buying energy efficient products . Signing pro-green petitions . Taking shorter showers . Car pooling . Composting . Saving energy . Walking instead of driving short distances . Lowering the thermostat by one degree .

Promoting Sustainable Behaviours

Using public transport . Installing insulation . Recycling . Buying local . Taking the train to domestic destinations . Reading energy labels . Switching off appliances at night . Cycling to work . Insta… . Waste less food . …ing against nuclear power . Buyin… …using a shopping bag . Eco-driving . Avoid… overseas flights . Washing at 30 degrees Celcius . Switching off lights . Buying energy efficient products . Signing pro-green petitions . Taking shorter showers . Car pooling . Composting . Saving energy . Walking instead of driving short distances . Lowering the thermostat by one degree .



Value Priorities



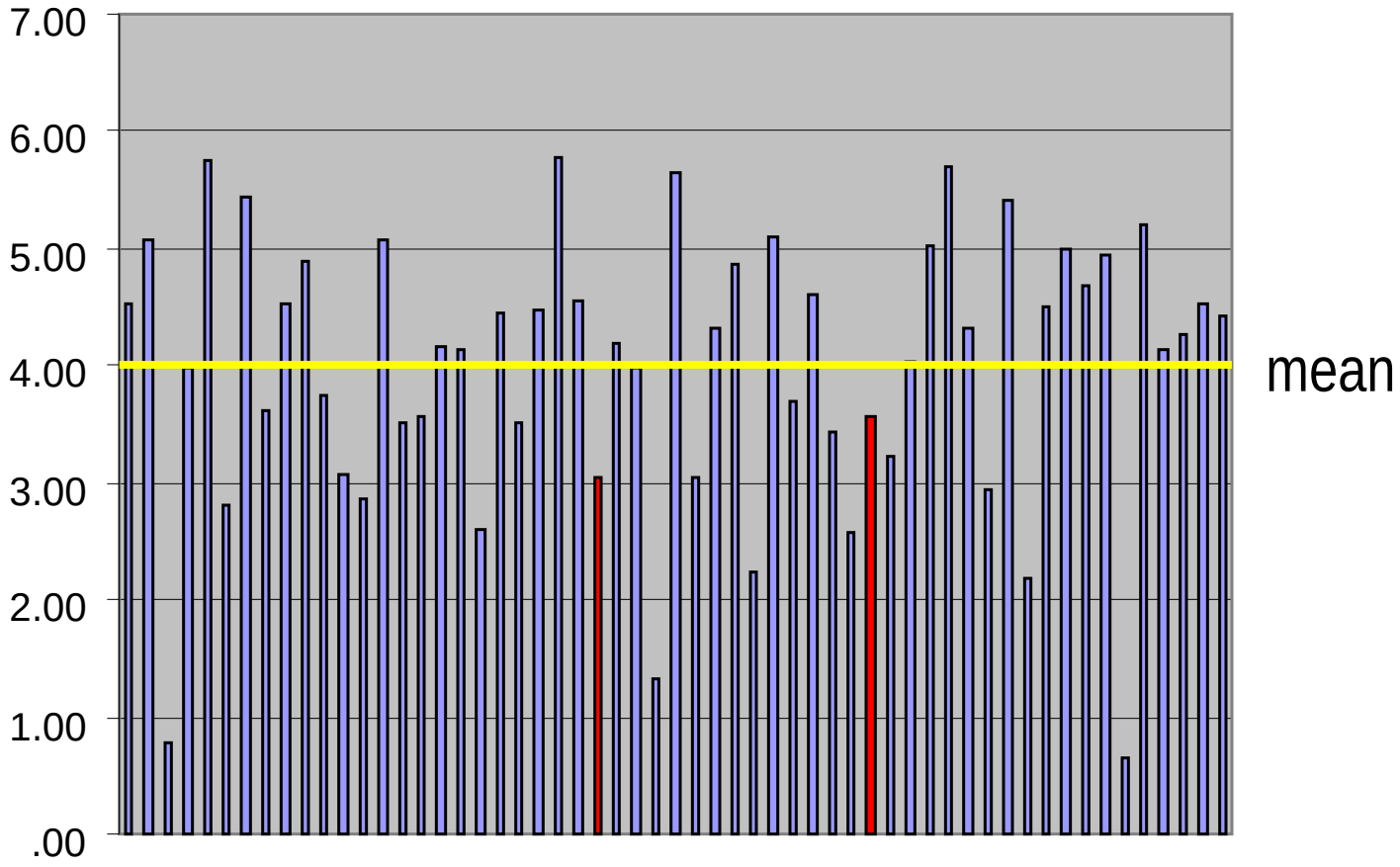
Value Circumplex (Schwartz, 1992)

Value Priorities



Value Circumplex (Schwartz, 1992)

Value Priorities



Students in Norway, *N* = 138

Value Priorities

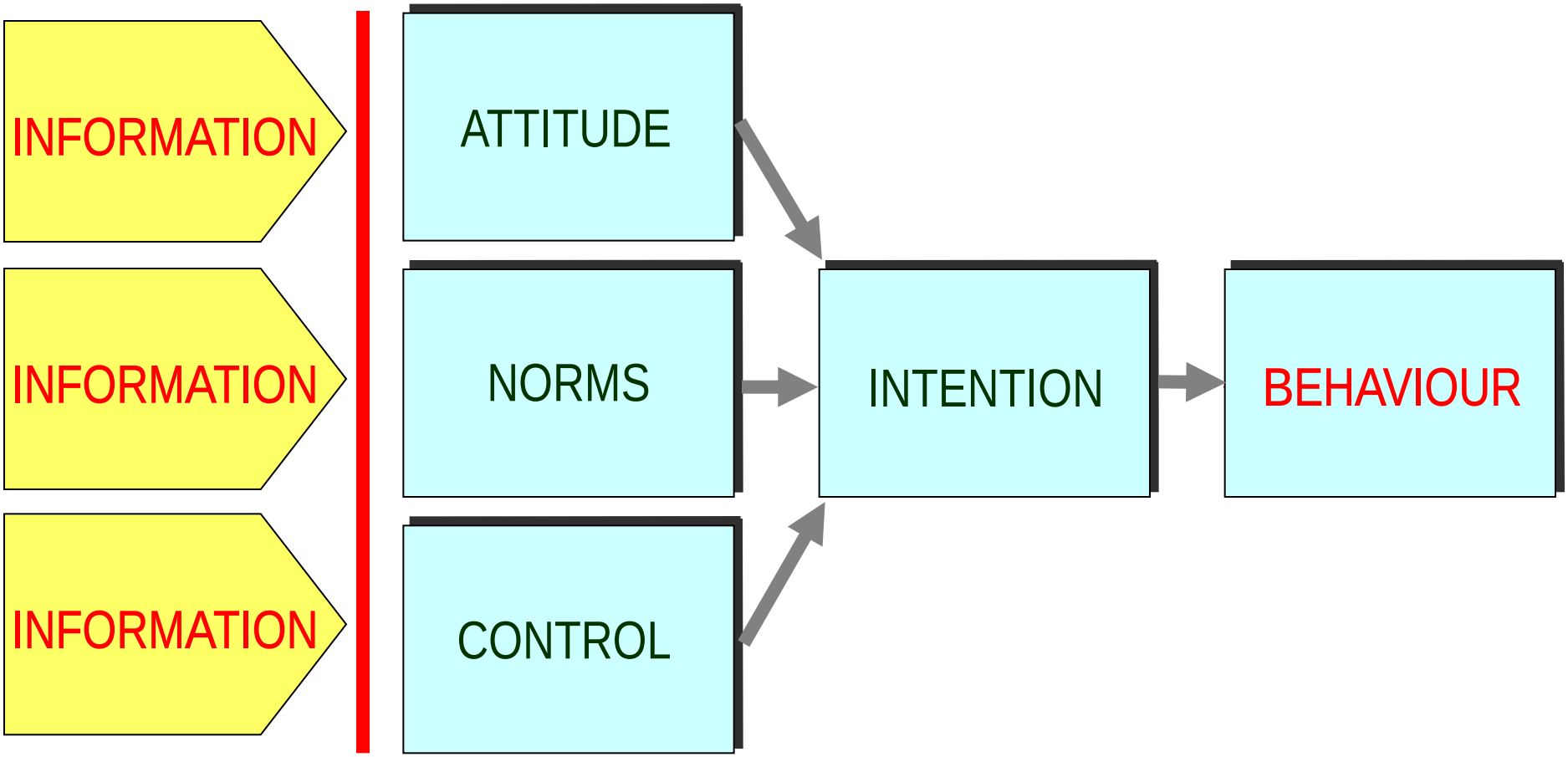
What do you see as important issues facing Britain today?

1. Economy
2. Law and order
3. Unemployment
4. Immigration
5. Health care
6. Education
7. Inflation
8. Foreign affairs
9. Social security
10. Poverty
11. Morality
12. Housing
13. Elderly care
14. Wages
15. Drug abuse
16. Petrol prices
17. EU
18. Overpopulation
19. Public services
20. Taxation
21. Environment
22. Council tax
23. Public transport
24. Value of pound stirling

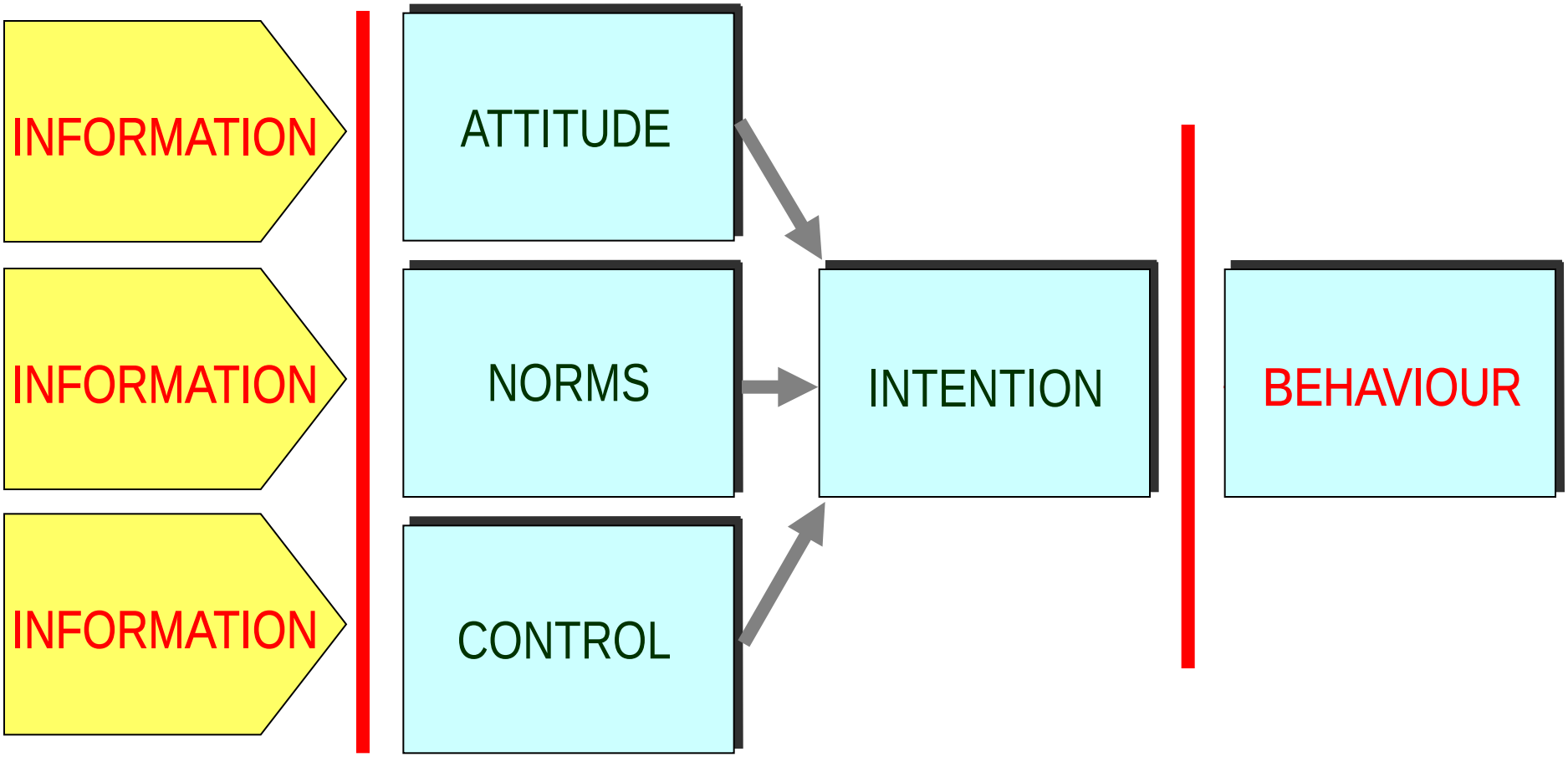
British adults, *N* = 956

©Ipsos/MORI Polls 2011

Habits are Bad News for Motivation-Based Interventions



Habits are Bad News for Motivation-Based Interventions



Promoting Sustainable Behaviours

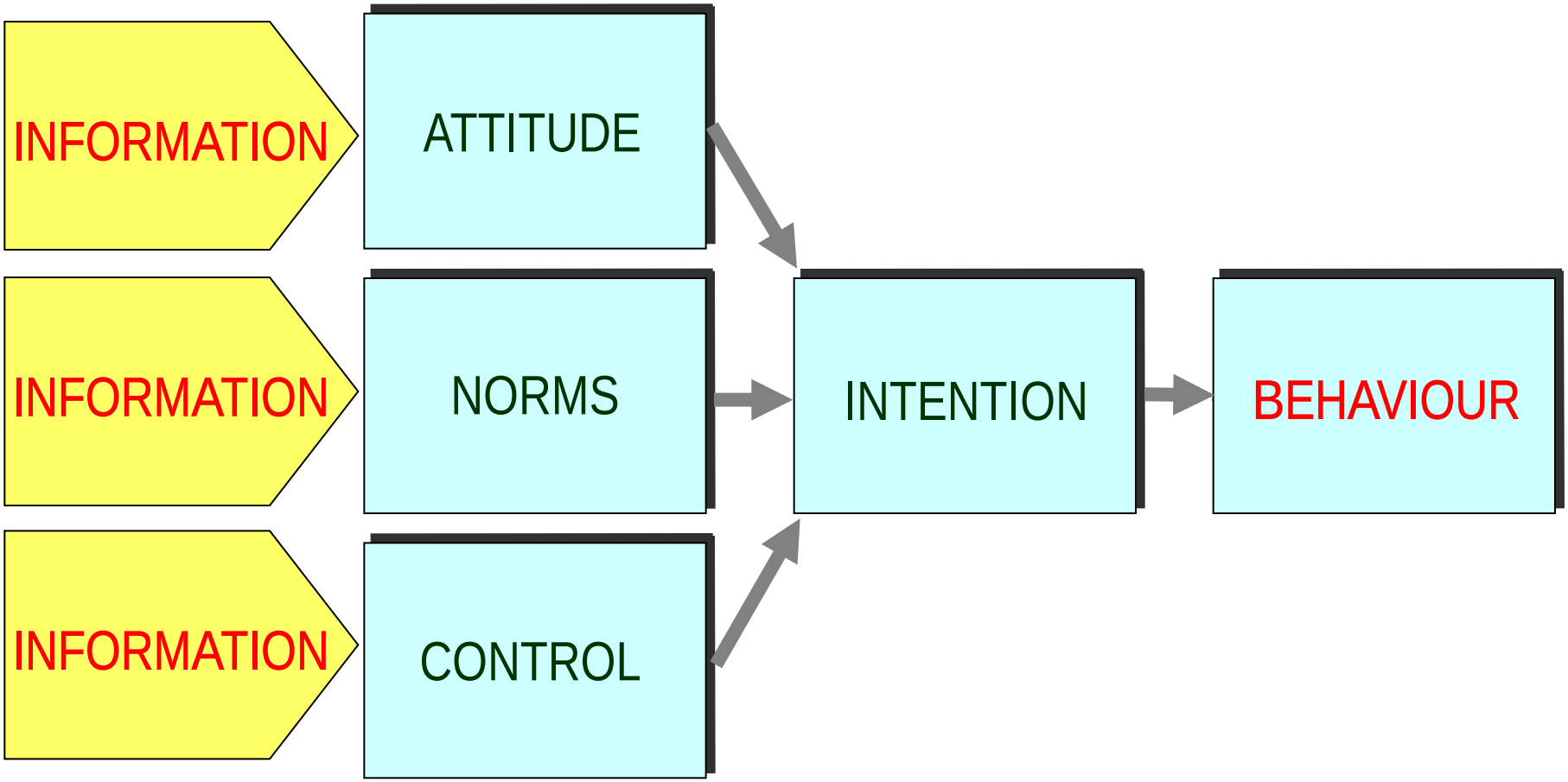


Using public transport . Installing insulation . Recycling . Buying local . Taking the train to domestic destinations . Reading energy labels . Switching off appliances at night . Cycling to work . Installing cavity wall insulation . Waste less food . Campaigning against nuclear power . Buying organic . Using a shopping bag . Eco-driving . Avoiding overseas flights . Washing at 30 degrees Celcius . Switching off lights . Buying energy efficient products . Signing pro-green petitions . Taking shorter showers . Car pooling . Composting . Saving energy . Walking instead of driving short distances . Lowering the thermostat by one degree .

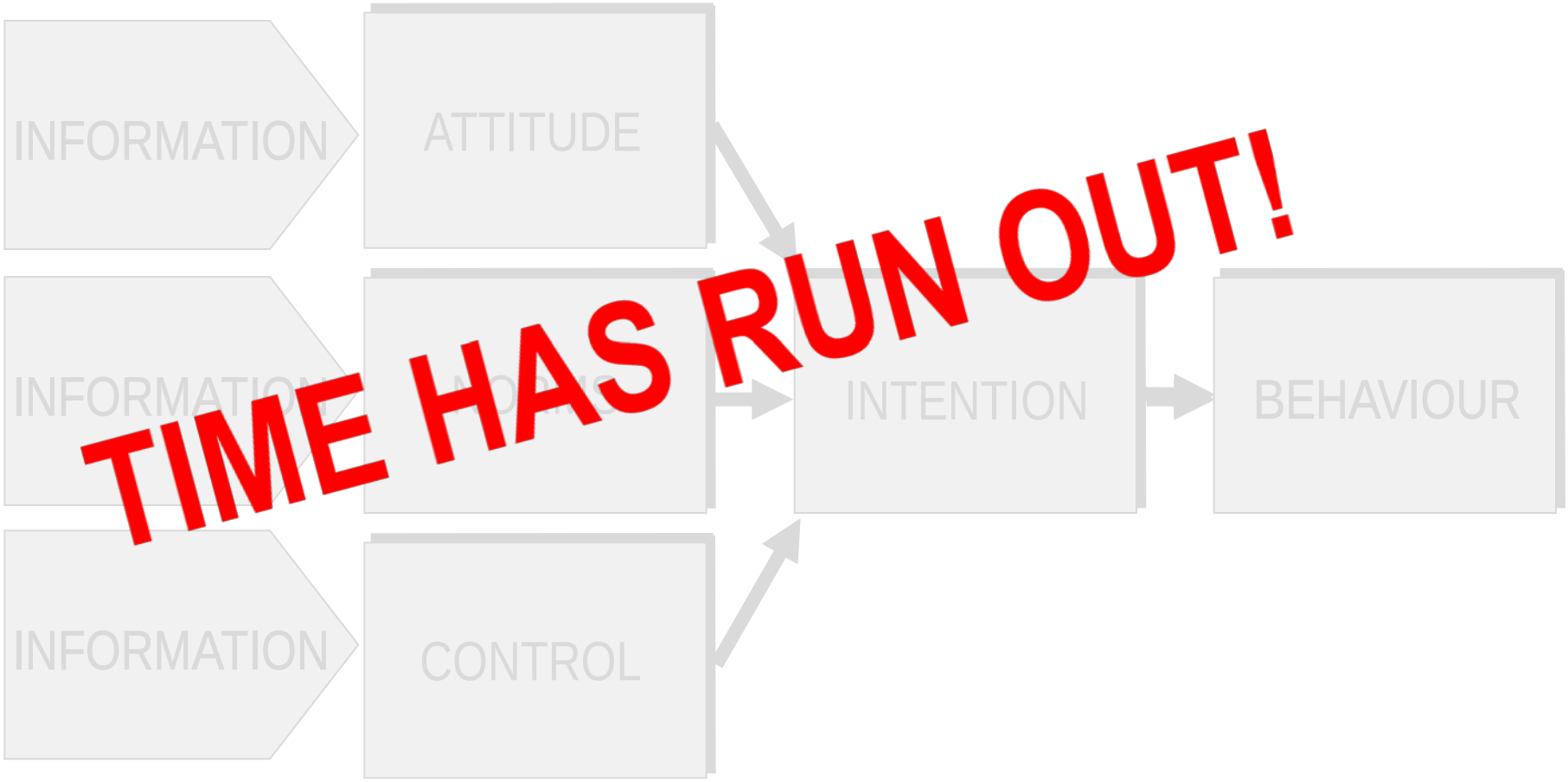
Motivation-Based Interventions



Motivation-Based Interventions



Motivation-Based Interventions

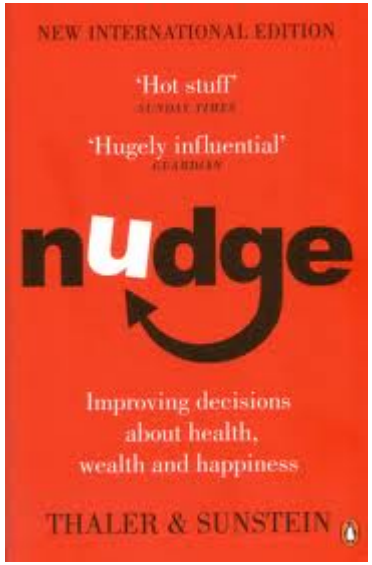


Motivation-Based Interventions

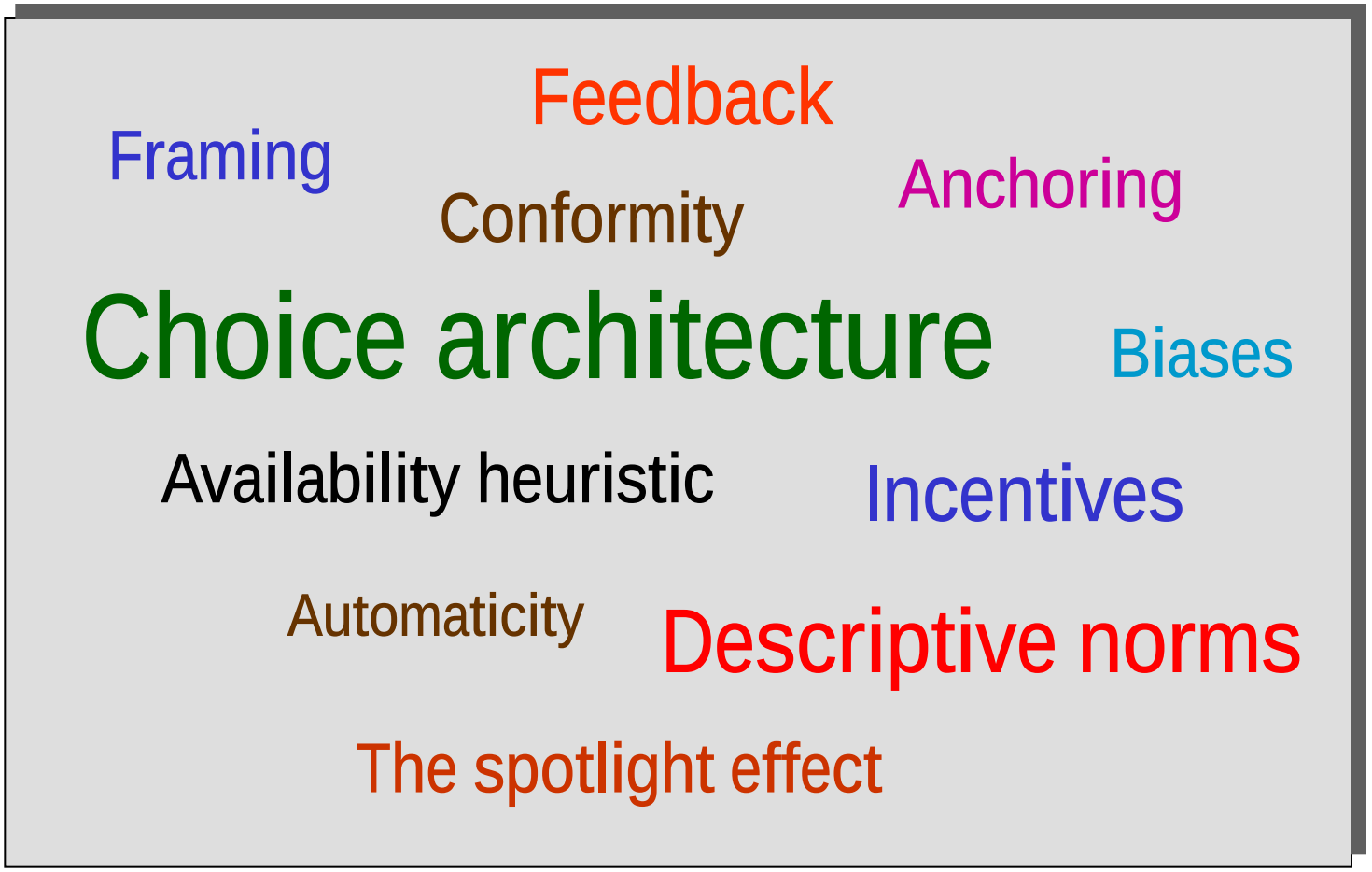


Policy Makers' Dreams

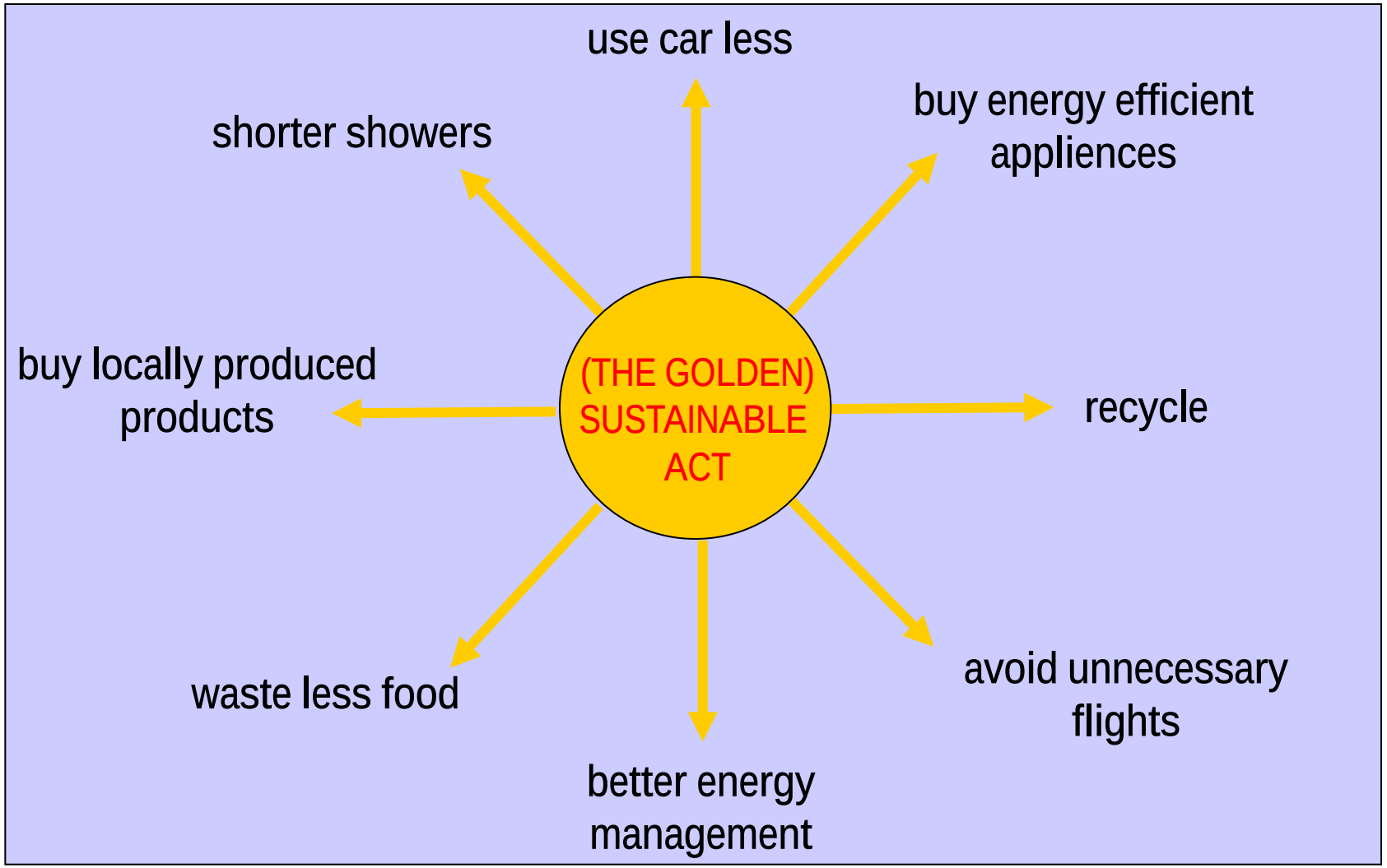
”Nudging”


NEW INTERNATIONAL EDITION
'Hot stuff'
'Hugely influential'
nudge
Improving decisions
about health,
wealth and happiness
THALER & SUNSTEIN

”Nudging”


Feedback
Framing
Anchoring
Conformity
Choice architecture
Biases
Availability heuristic
Incentives
Automaticity
Descriptive norms
The spotlight effect

Catalyst Behaviours ("Spillover Effect")



Promoting Sustainable Behaviours

Using public transport . Installing insulation . Recycling . Buying local . Taking the train to domestic destinations . Reading energy labels . Switching off appli… Cycling to work . … meter . Waste less f… E… Protesting against nuclear power . B… organic food . Using a shopping bag . Eco-driving . Avoiding overseas flights . Washing at 30 degrees Celcius . Switching off lights . Buying energy efficient products . Signing pro-green petitions . Taking shorter showers . Car pooling . Composting . Saving energy . Walking instead of driving short distances . Lowering the thermostat by one degree .



Prevention and Education



Newly qualified drivers

Prevention and Education



Newly qualified drivers

Habit Discontinuities

- Habits may (temporarily) be broken

Moving house
Changing jobs
Starting a family
Retirement
Changes in infrastructure
Legislation
Economic downfall

Verplanken & Wood (2006), *Journal of Public Policy and Marketing*

Habit Discontinuities

- Habits may (temporarily) be broken
- Windows of opportunity for change
  - Re-orientation
  - Negotiating new behaviours
  - Need for information, deliberation
  - Interventions potentially more effective

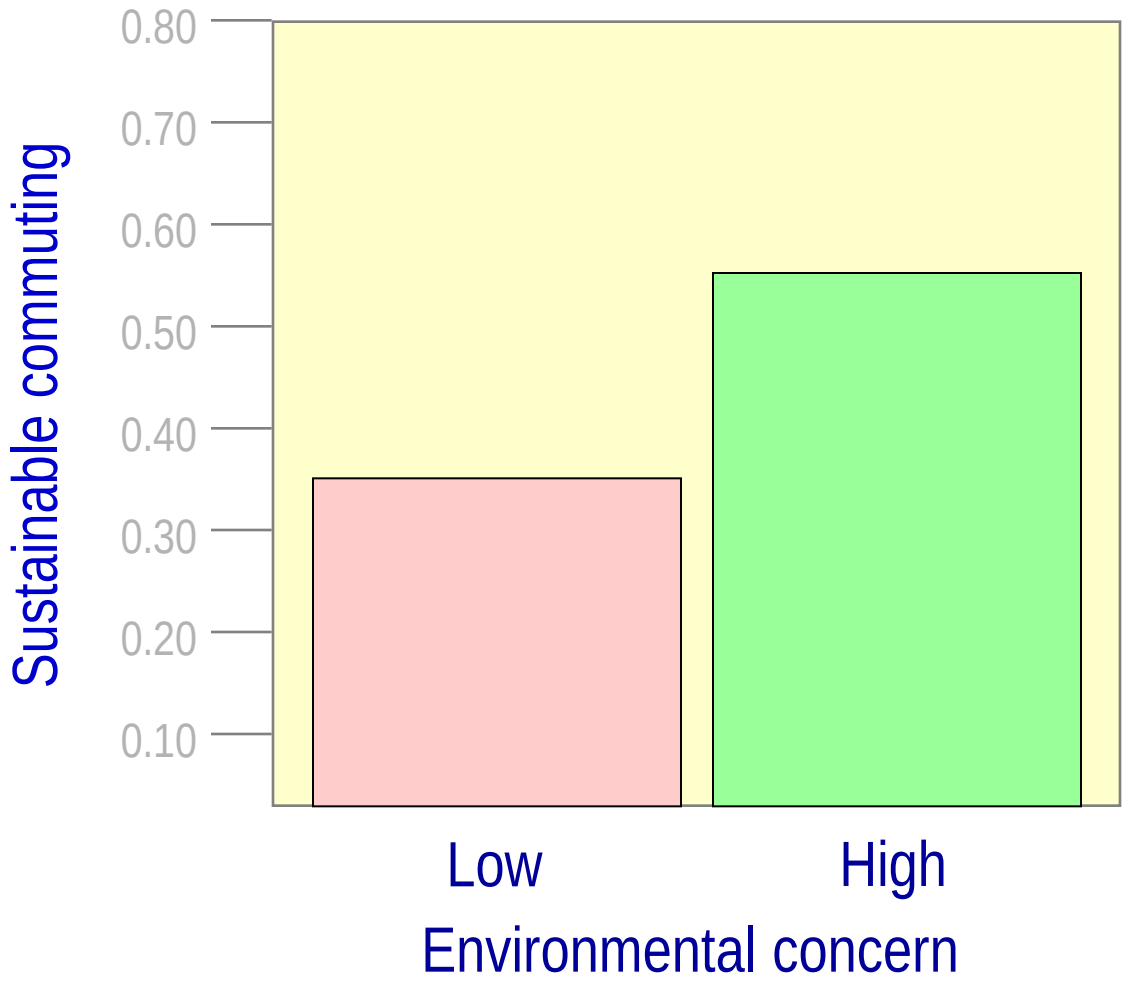
Verplanken & Wood (2006), *Journal of Public Policy and Marketing*

Habit Discontinuities

- Habits may (temporarily) be broken
- Windows of opportunity for change
- Some circumstantial evidence

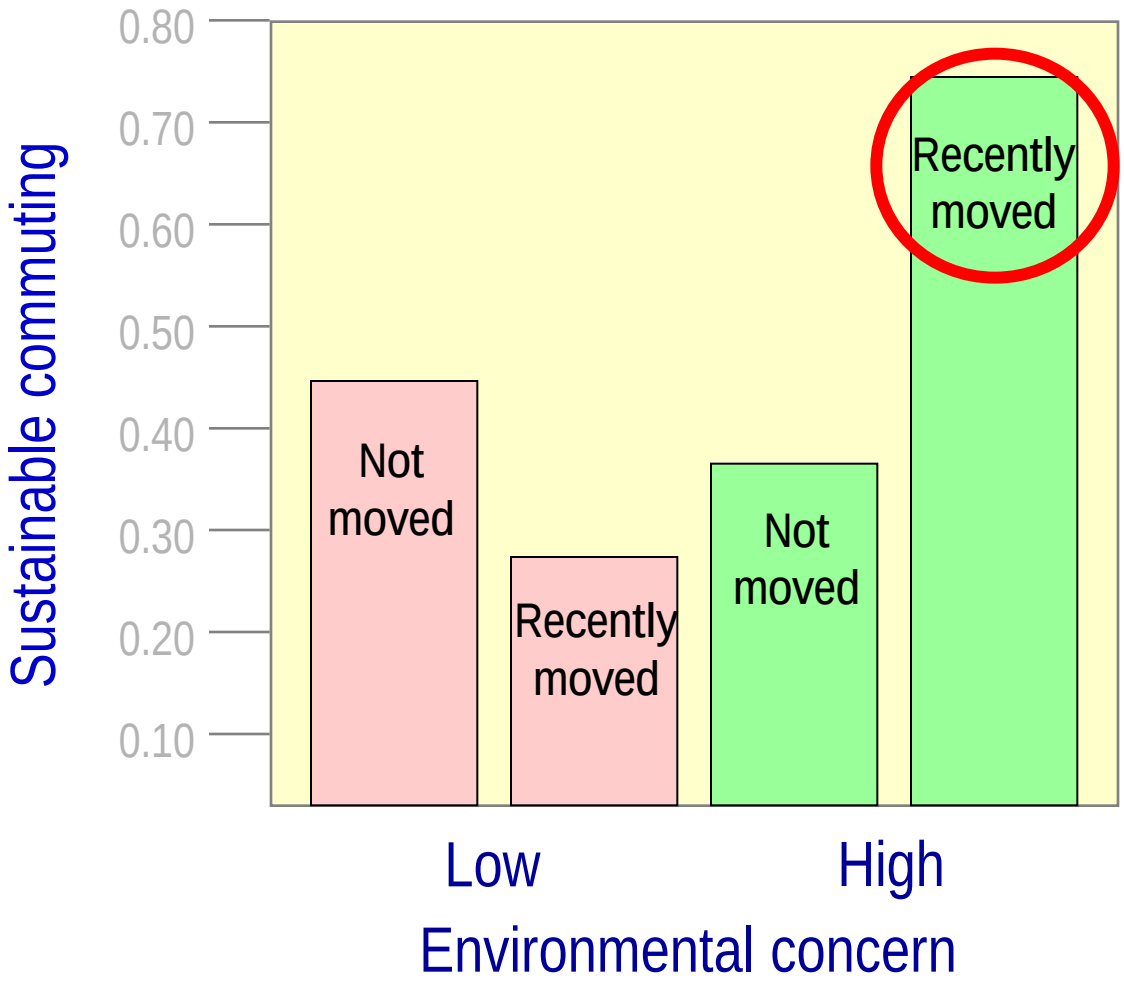
Verplanken, Walker, Davis, & Jurasek (2008), *Journal of Environmental Psychology*

Habit Discontinuities



Verplanken, Walker, Davis, & Jurasek (2008), *Journal of Environmental Psychology*

Habit Discontinuities

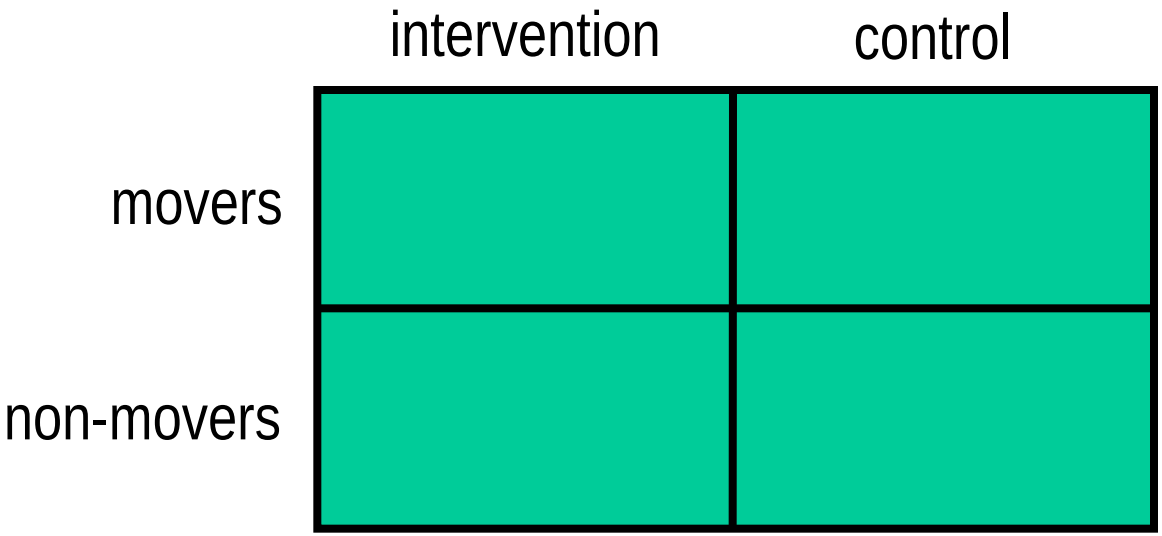


Verplanken, Walker, Davis, & Jurasek (2008), *Journal of Environmental Psychology*

Habit Discontinuities

- Habits may (temporarily) be broken
- Windows of opportunity for change
- Some circumstancial evidence
- Field experiment: intervention to promote sustainable behaviours among movers vs non-movers

Habit Discontinuities



Habit Formation

- Habitual features are desirable for behaviours we want to promote

Frequent and automatic behaviour
Cue-controlled
Difficult to change

Habit Formation

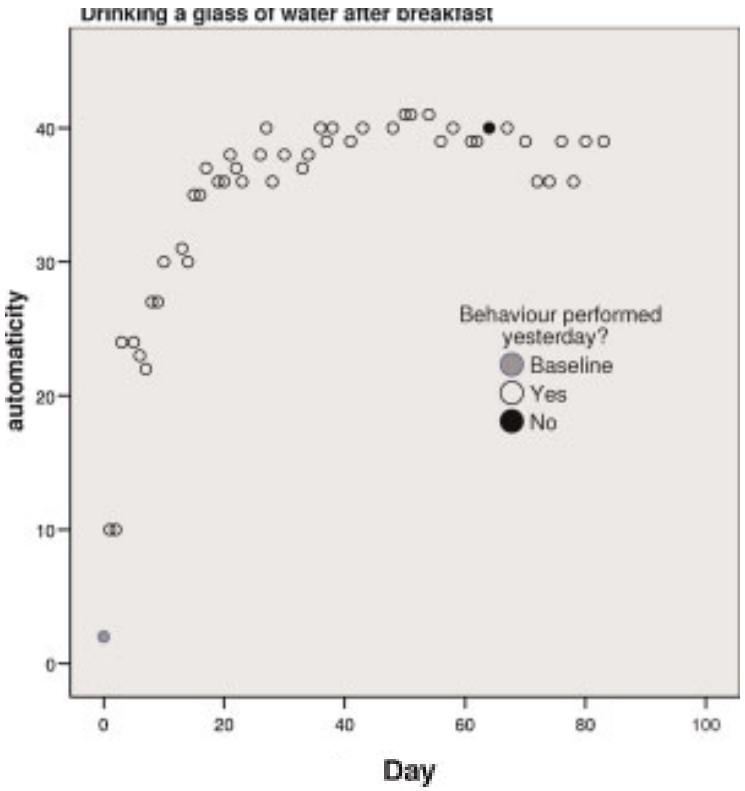
- Habitual features are desirable for behaviours we want to promote
- Habituation as intervention goal

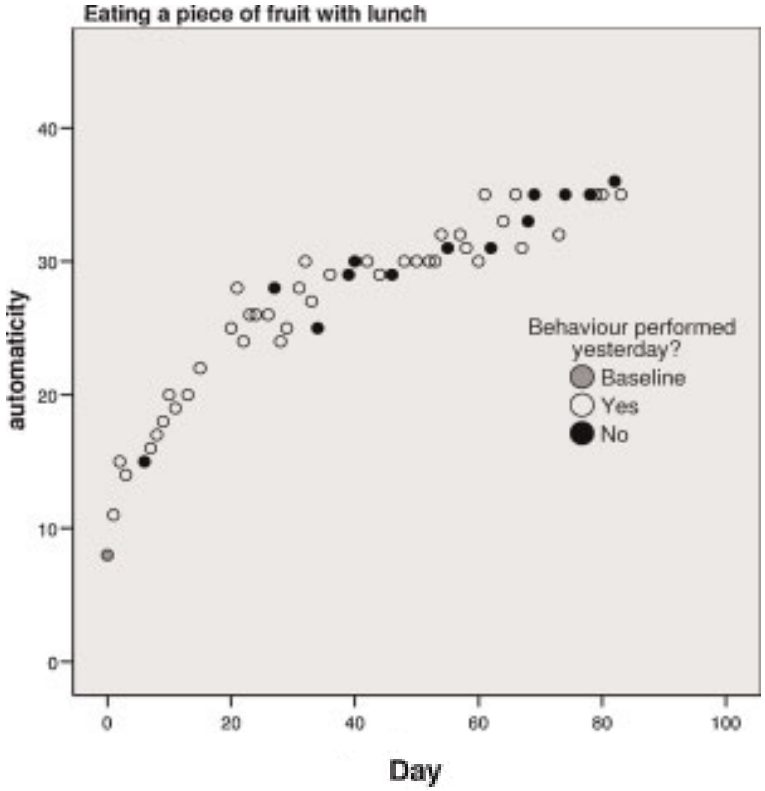
Habit Formation

- Habitual features are desirable for behaviours we want to promote
- Habituation as intervention goal
- Habit formation modelling

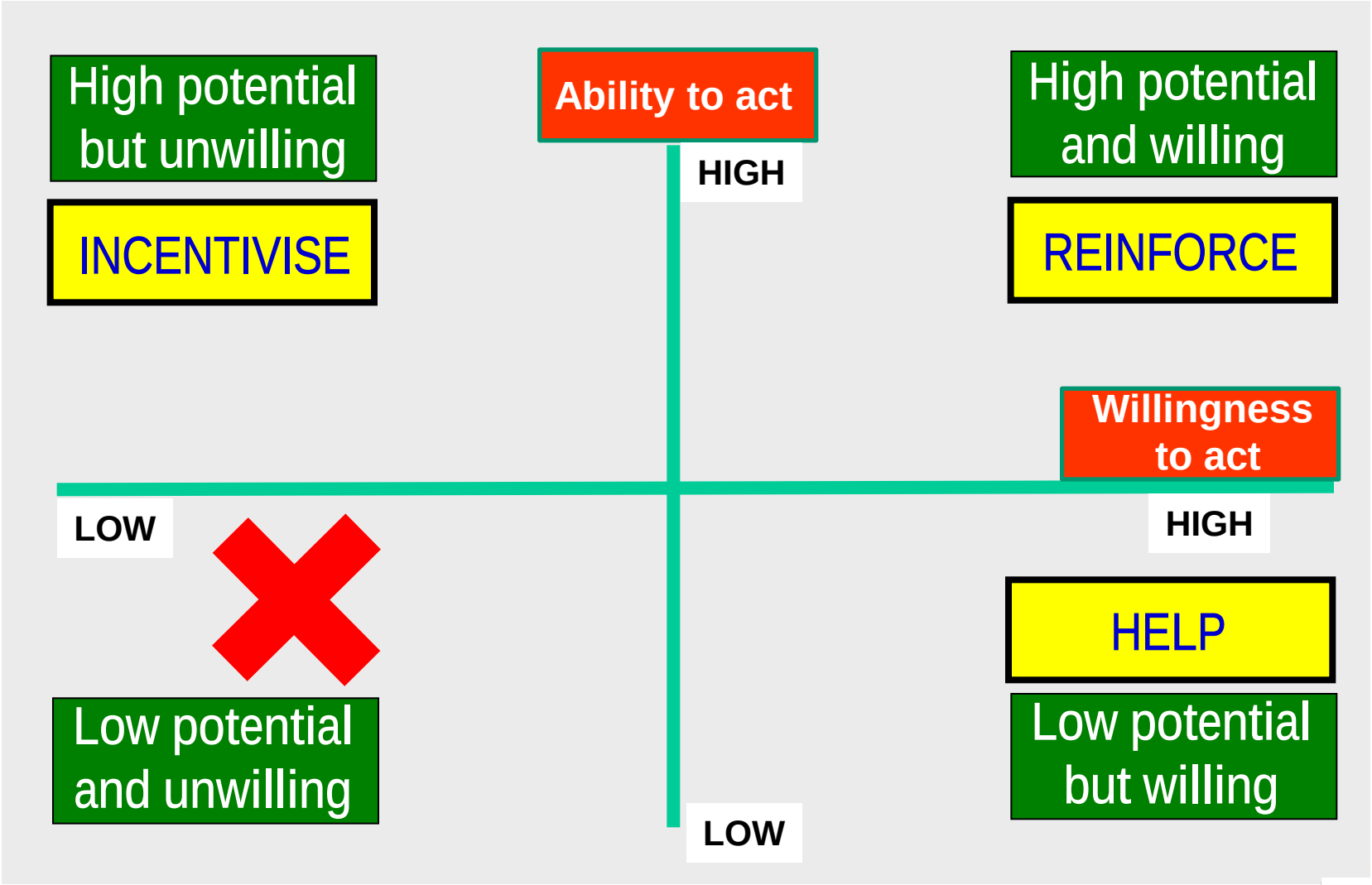
Modelling Habit Formation

(Lally et al., 2010)

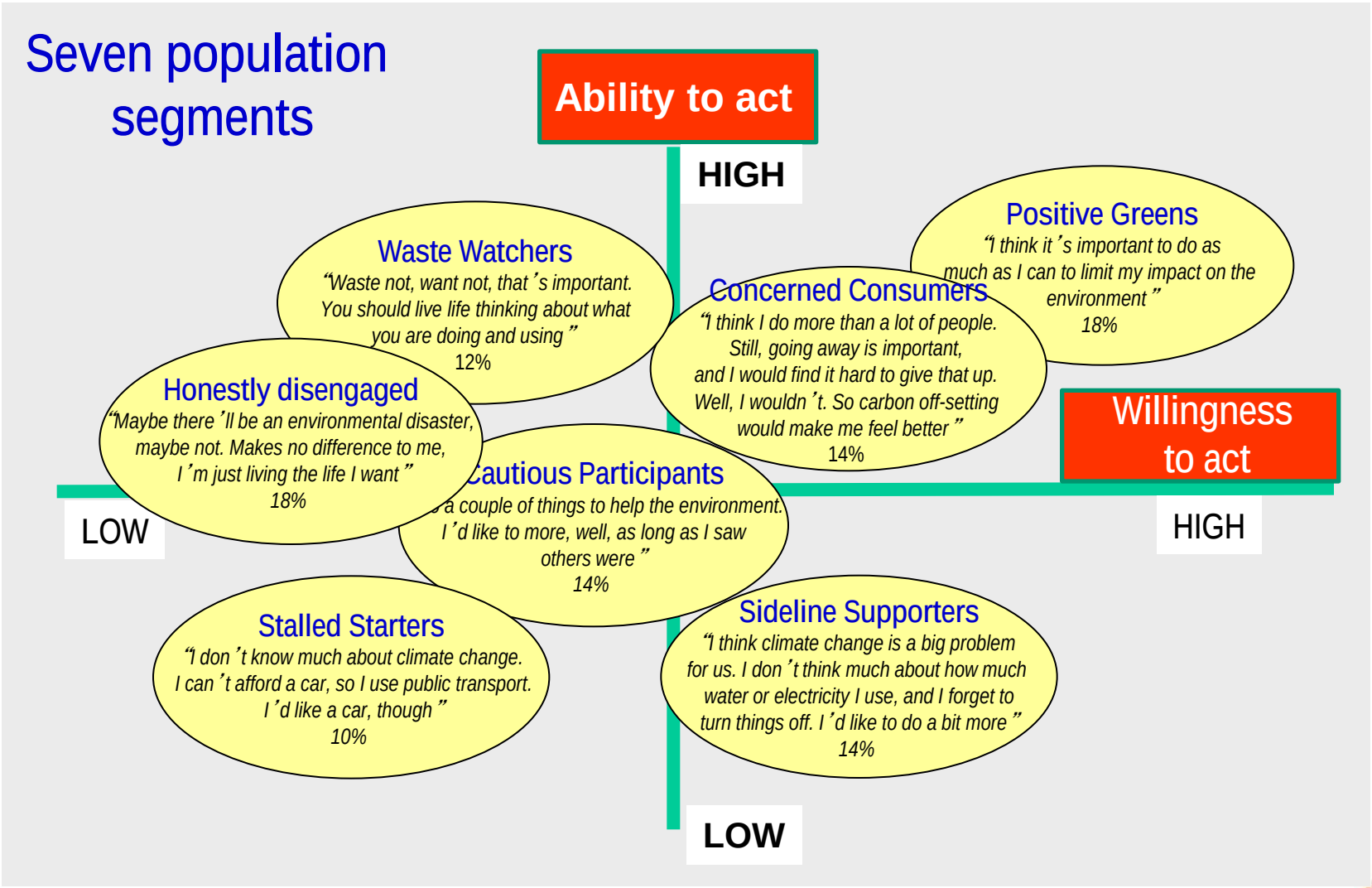




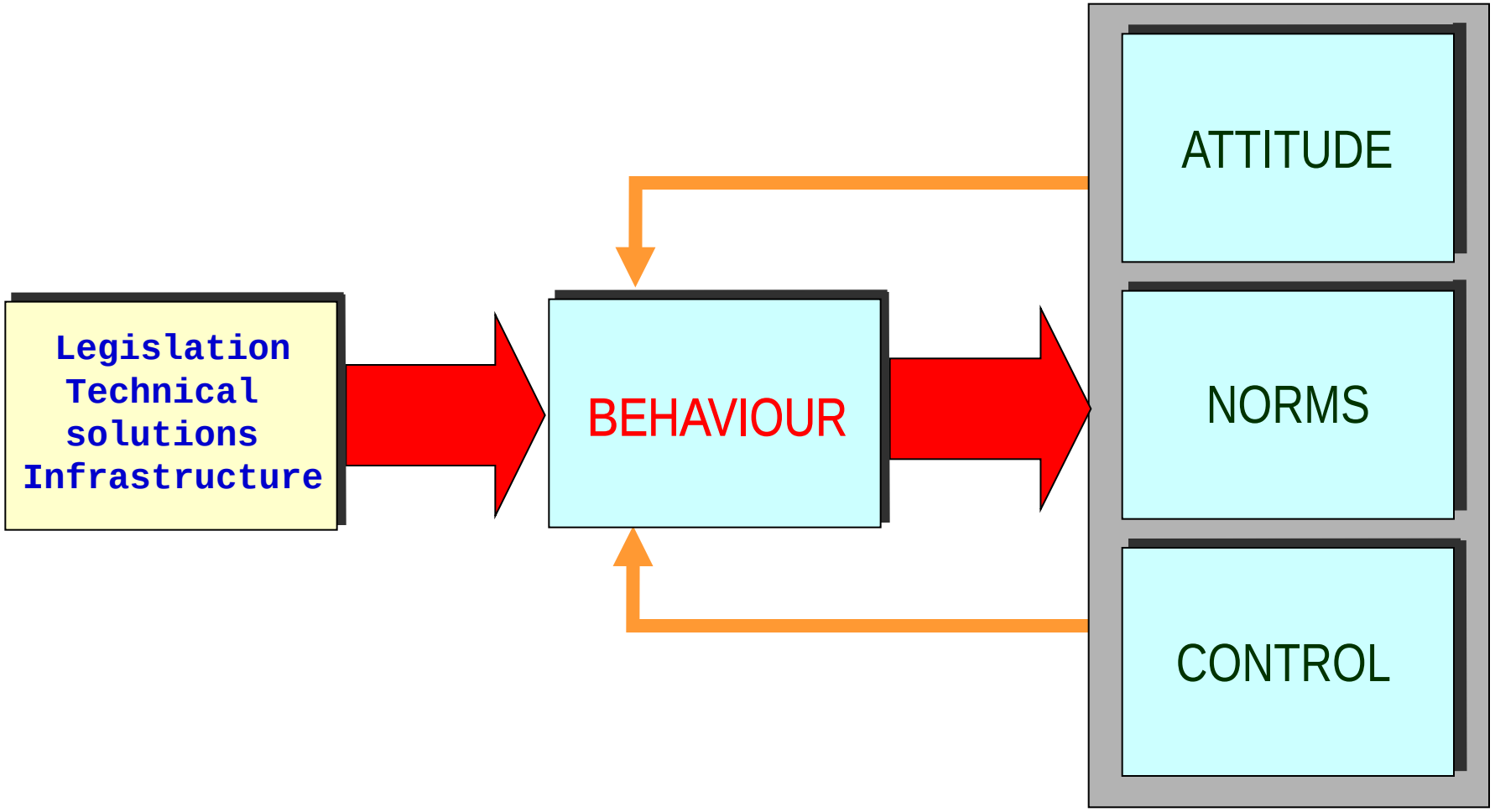
Segmentation



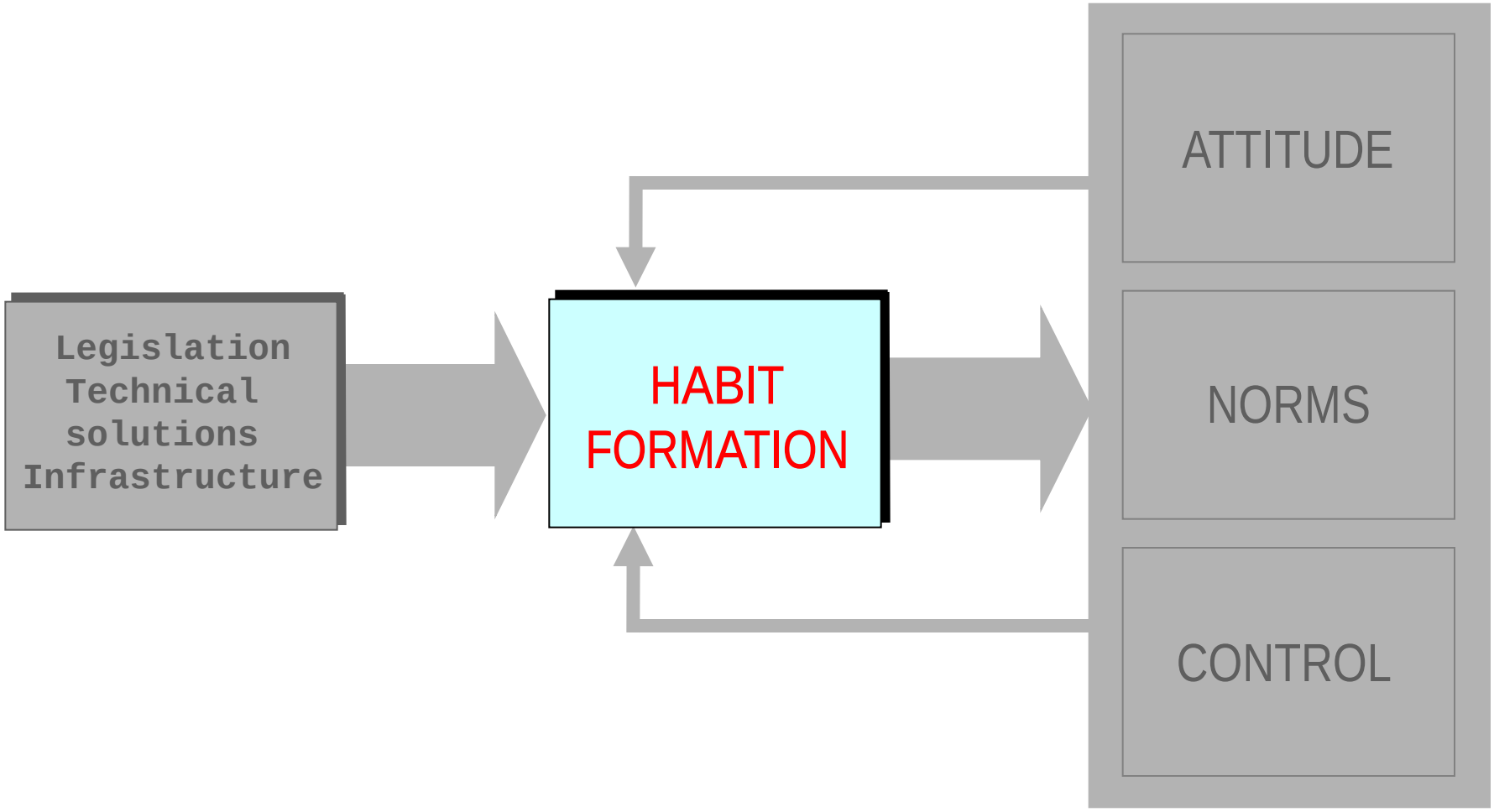
Segmentation



Why Not Start By Changing Behaviour?



Why Not Start By Changing Behaviour?



Why Not Start By Changing Behaviour?

- Seat belts
- Smoking ban
- Congestion tax
  - ✓London (+)
  - ✓Stockholm (+)
  - ✓Manchester (-)
  - ✓Melbourne (+)
- Not merely acceptance, but genuine attitude change

Why Not Start By Changing Behaviour?

We Need Brave Politicians!

and smart

What's In For You?

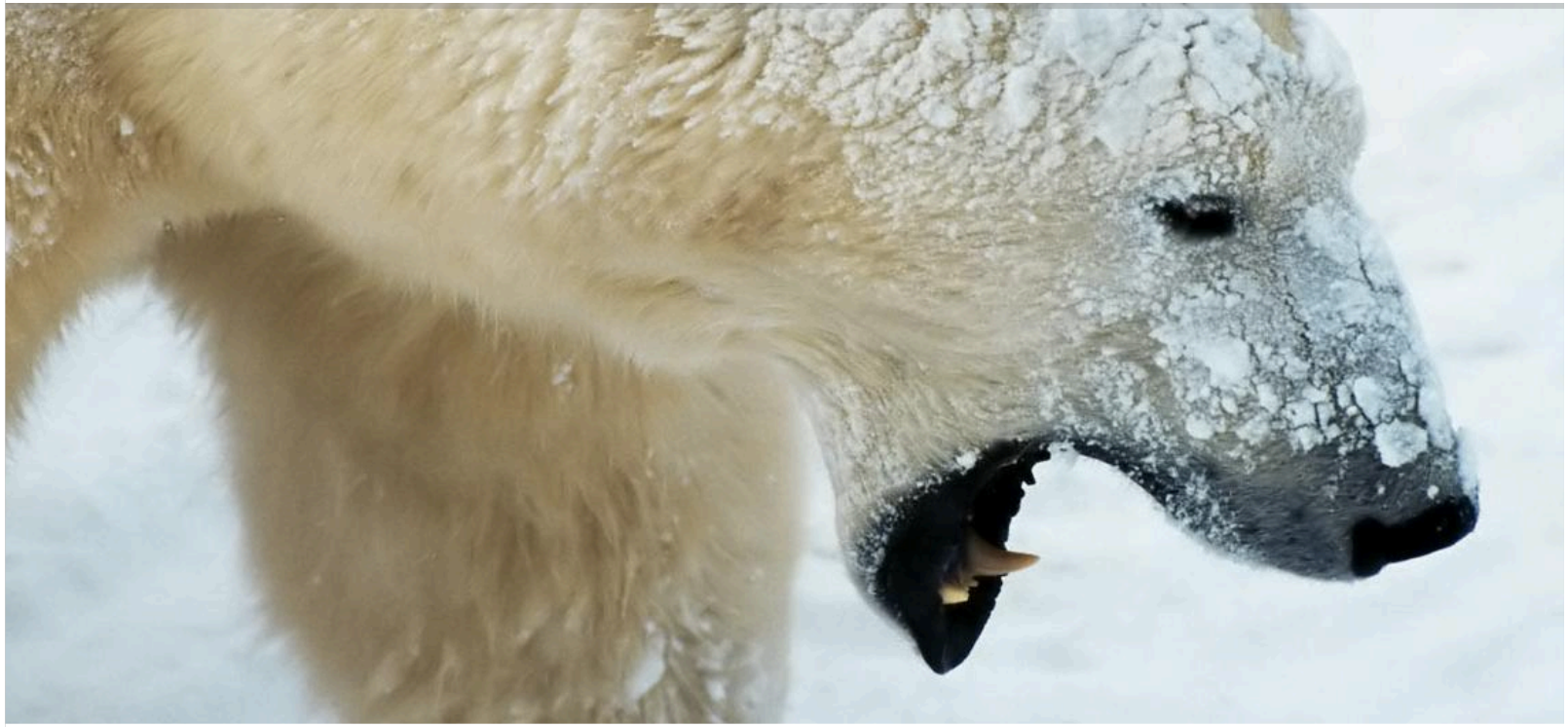
<< Whilst I do acknowledge that the issue of climate change is probably the most important problem humanity has faced, I surprise myself in my own ability to ignore this. >>

(Anonymous participant, June 2012)

What's In For You?



What's In For You?



What's In For You?



What's In For You?



What's In For You?



What's In For You?



The Environment and You

<< To harm any part of the environment is to harm one's self, as we are not separate or other than the world in which we live >>

(Yahoo discussion forum on Buddhism and the Environment, June 2012)

THANK YOU

b.verplanken@bath.ac.uk

